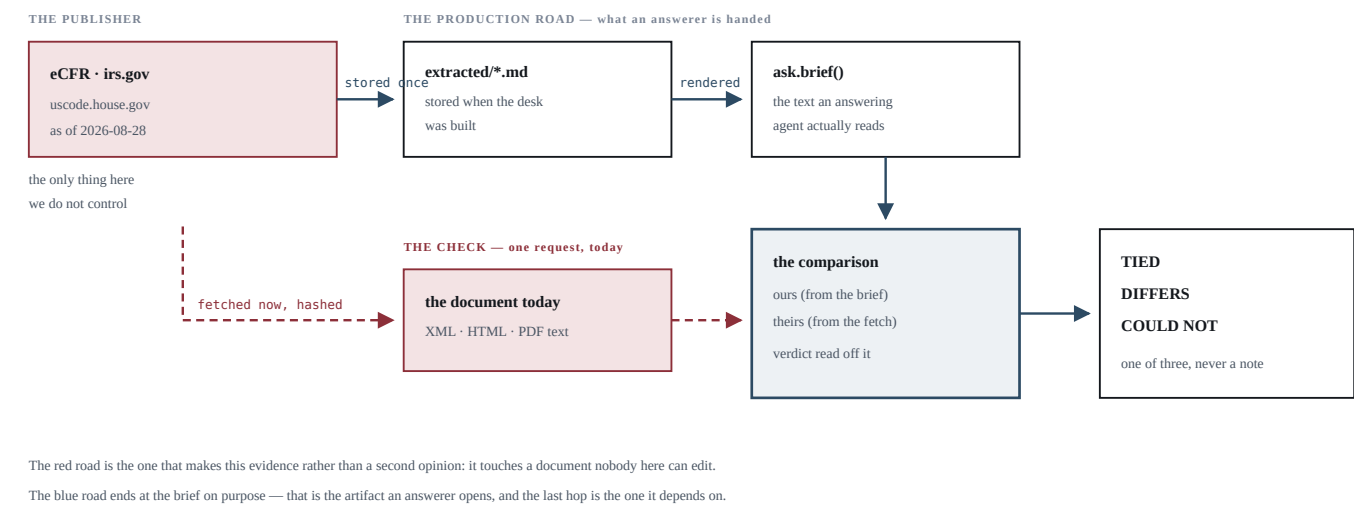


meals-and-entertainment

Every passage this desk hands to an answering agent, put back to the publisher that wrote it. **The question is not whether our tests pass.** It is whether the authority we serve is what the authority actually says — which no test in this repository can answer, because they all read the same stored files.



The same passage, two roads. They meet at the comparison, and the verdict is read off that block rather than written ahead of it.

The roster

0	0	44 of 44	6
DIFFERS	COULD NOT	TIED	SOURCES FETCHED LIVE

Of the **44** that tied, **44** matched the publisher's characters exactly, **0** matched only once whitespace was ignored, and **0** carry a marked omission and were checked segment by segment, in order. All three are declared, and explained under what this does not prove.

44 + 0 + 0 = 44, which is the tied count above. THE SENTENCE USED TO NAME TWO OF THE THREE and so did not add up — 43 and 4 against 49 tied on the cash desk, with the two marked omissions unaccounted for. A breakdown that does not sum to its own total is the failure this exhibit exists to catch, printed by the exhibit.

The sample of one, worked end to end

The longest passage on this desk, because a long one has the most places to be wrong.

1 · THE FIGURE — AND WHERE A READER SEES IT

Not a row of a database: the paragraph of authority the desk hands an answering agent under the citation IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "Exception to the 50% Limit for Meals". It is read out of ask.brief(), which is the text that agent opens, and it is 2,568 characters long.

Your meal expense isn't subject to the 50% limit if the expense meets one of the following exceptions. Exception 1—expenses treated as compensation. In general, expenses for goods, services, and facilities, to the extent the expenses are treated by the taxpayer, with respect to entertainment, amusement, or recreation, as compensation to an employee and as wages to the employee for tax purposes. Exception 2—employee's reimbursed expenses. If you are an employee, you aren't subject to the 50% limit on expenses for which your employer reimburses you under an accountable plan. Accountable plans are discussed in chapter 6. Exception 3—self-employed reimbursed expenses. If you are self-employed, your deductible meal expenses aren't subject to the 50% limit if all of the following requirements are met. You have these expenses as an independent contractor. Your customer or client reimburses you or gives you an allowance for these expenses in connection with services you perform. You provide adequate records of these expenses to your customer or client. (See chapter 5.) In this case, your client or customer is subject to the 50% limit on the expenses. Example. You are a self-employed attorney who adequately accounts for meal expenses to a client who reimburses you for these expenses. You aren't subject to the limitation on meal expenses. If the client can deduct the expenses, the client is subject to the 50% limit. If you (as an independent contractor) have expenses for meals related to providing services for a client but don't adequately account for and seek reimbursement from the client for those expenses, you are subject to the 50% limit on non-entertainment-related meals and the entertainment-related meal expenses are nondeductible to you. Exception 4—recreational expenses for employees. You aren't subject to the 50% limit for expenses for recreational, social, or similar activities (including facilities) such as a holiday party or a summer picnic. Exception 5—advertising expenses. You aren't subject to the 50% limit if you provide meals to the general public as a means of advertising or promoting goodwill in the community. For example, neither the expense of sponsoring a television or radio show nor the expense of distributing free food and beverages to the general public is subject to the 50% limit. Exception 6—sale of meals. You aren't subject to the 50% limit if you actually sell meals to the public. For example, if you run a restaurant, your expense for the food you furnish to your customers isn't subject to the 50% limit.

2 · THE CALL — COPY-PASTABLE, WITH THE REAL VALUES IN IT

```
curl -sS --compressed "https://www.irs.gov/publications/p463"
```

Fetches 2026-09-07 03:19:56Z · 848,610 bytes · SHA-256
d85160c09cafea4b314da139de7c943293f491a9e63011bd912c2ddc3ce140ed

3 · THE DERIVATION — WHAT HAPPENS BETWEEN THE TWO

The response is turned into plain text: an XML or HTML document has its inline tags closed up and its block tags turned into a space, a PDF is read page by page. Both sides are then folded the same way — Unicode normalised, and the typographic quotes and dashes publishers vary between renderings mapped to their plain forms. **Nothing else is changed.** The stored text either occurs in the publisher's document or it does not.

4 · THE INDEPENDENT SOURCE — CAPTURED, NOT SUMMARISED

The publisher's own words around the match, quoted verbatim out of the bytes whose hash is printed above. **A reader re-fetches that URL, recomputes the hash, and gets the same digits** — which is a check a photograph cannot offer.

...deduction is allowed for entertainment expenses. Exception to the 50% Limit for Meals Your meal expense isn't subject to the 50% limit if the expense meets one of the following exceptions. Exception 1-expenses treated as compensation. In general, expenses for goods, services, and facilities, to the extent the expenses are treated by the taxpayer, with respect to entertainment, amusement, or recreation, as compensation to an employee and as wages to the employee for tax purposes. Exception 2-employee's reimbursed expenses. If you are an employee, you aren't subject to the 50% limit on expenses for which your employer reimburses you under an accountable plan. Accountable plans are discussed in chapter 6. Exception 3-self-employed reimbursed expenses. If you are self-employed, your deductible meal expenses aren't subject to the 50% limit if all of the following requirements are met. You have these expenses as an independent contractor. Your customer or client reimburses you or gives you an allowance for these expenses in connection with services you perform. You provide adequate records of these expenses to your customer or client. (See chapter 5.) In this case, your client or customer is subject to the 50% limit on the expenses. Example. You are a self-employed attorney who adequately accounts for meal expenses to a client who reimburses you for these expenses. You aren't subject to the limitation on meal expenses. If the client can deduct the expenses, the client is subject to the 50% limit. If you (as an independent contractor) have expenses for meals related to providing services for a client but don't adequately account for and seek reimbursement from the client for those expenses, you are subject to the 50% limit on non-entertainment-related meals and the entertainment-related meal expenses are nondeductible to you. Exception 4-recreational expenses for employees. You aren't subject to the 50% limit for expenses for recreational, social, or similar activities (including facilities) such as a holiday party or a summer picnic. Exception 5-advertising expenses. You aren't subject to the 50% limit if you provide meals to the general public as a means of advertising or promoting goodwill in the community. For example, neither the expense of sponsoring a television or radio show nor the expense of distributing free food and beverages to the general public is subject to the 50% limit. Exception 6-sale of meals. You aren't subject to the 50% limit if you actually sell meals to the public. For example, if you run a restaurant, your expense for the food you furnish to your customers isn't subject to the 50% limit. Individuals subject to "hours of service" limits. You can deduct a higher percentage of your meal expenses while traveling away from your tax home if the meals take place during or incident to any period subject to the Department of Transportation's "hours of...

5 · THE COMPARISON

ours	(ask.brief → IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "Exception to the 50% Limi)
	2,568 characters
theirs	(https://www.irs.gov/publications/p463)
	2,568 of them found, verbatim, in the document fetched above
diff	none

TIED — the publisher’s characters exactly

Every passage on this desk

VERDICT	CITATION	CHARS	HOW / WHY
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-2(a)	840	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-2(b)(1)	667	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-2(b)(2)	764	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-2(c)	446	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-2(d)	901	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-2(e)	84	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-11(a)	716	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-11(b)(1)(i)	1,591	exact

VERDICT	CITATION	CHARS	HOW / WHY
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-11(b)(1)(ii)	1,388	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-11(b)(1)(iii)	1,226	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-11(b)(2)	194	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-11(c)	154	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(a)(1)	475	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(a)(2)	311	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(a)(4)(i)	450	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(a)(4)(ii)	280	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(a)(4)(iii)	725	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(b)(1)	272	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(b)(2)	430	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(b)(3)	318	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(b)(8)	173	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(b)(9)	410	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(1)	295	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(2)(i)(A)	814	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(2)(i)(B)	920	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(2)(i)(D)	954	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(2)(ii)(A)	872	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(2)(iii)(A)	1,752	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(2)(iv)(A)	552	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(2)(v)(A)	1,036	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5(c)(2)(iii)(A)	418	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5(c)(2)(iii)(B)	1,357	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5(f)(4)(i)	1,362	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5(j)(1)	529	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5T(a)	1,466	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5T(b)(1)	332	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5T(b)(2)	862	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5T(b)(3)	998	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "50% Limit" – costs to include or exclude	240	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "50% Limit" – taking turns paying for meals	235	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "50% Limit" – the general rule	496	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "Exception to the 50% Limit for Meals"	2,568	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "Proving business purpose"	806	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "What Are Adequate Records?"	1,616	exact

The sources, and that they can disagree with us

- **S1** — Treasury Regulation § 1.274-12 — Limitation on deductions for certain food or beverage expenses paid or incurred after December 31, 2017
<https://www.ecfr.gov/api/versioner/v1/full/2026-08-28/title-26.xml?section=1.274-12>
- **S2** — Treasury Regulation § 1.274-11 — Disallowance of deductions for certain entertainment, amusement, or recreation expenditures paid or incurred after December 31, 2017
<https://www.ecfr.gov/api/versioner/v1/full/2026-08-28/title-26.xml?section=1.274-11>
- **S3** — Treasury Regulation § 1.162-2 — Traveling expenses
<https://www.ecfr.gov/api/versioner/v1/full/2026-08-28/title-26.xml?section=1.162-2>
- **S4** — Treasury Regulation § 1.274-5 — Substantiation requirements
<https://www.ecfr.gov/api/versioner/v1/full/2026-08-28/title-26.xml?section=1.274-5>
- **S5** — Treasury Regulation § 1.274-5T — Substantiation requirements (temporary)
<https://www.ecfr.gov/api/versioner/v1/full/2026-08-28/title-26.xml?section=1.274-5T>
- **S6** — IRS Publication 463 (2025) — Travel, Gift, and Car Expenses
<https://www.irs.gov/publications/p463>

Not one of these is ours. None is a cache, a fixture or a second copy of our own record — which is the test the tie-out skill puts first: **could this disagree with me?** Each one can, and two of them did.

How to run this yourself

Every step below has the real values already in it. Nothing here needs me.

1 · RE-RUN THE WHOLE CHECK

```
cd desk && python -B tools/tieout.py
```

It fetches every source live and writes `tie-outs/findings.json`. Expect it to take a few minutes: it pauses between requests rather than hammering the publishers.

2 · REBUILD THESE DOCUMENTS FROM THAT RUN

```
cd desk && python -B tools/tieout_exhibit.py
```

3 · CHECK ONE LINE BY HAND, WITHOUT EITHER SCRIPT

Take any row in the roster, fetch its URL, and look for the text yourself:

```
curl -sS --compressed "https://www.irs.gov/publications/p463" | shasum -a 256
```

If that hash matches the one printed with the exemplar above, you are reading the same bytes this document read. Then search the document for the passage — the desk prints it under that citation in the brief:

```
cd desk && python -B -c "import sys; sys.path.insert(0,'.'); import ask, record, pathlib; \
print(ask.brief('show me', record.load(pathlib.Path('desks/meals-and-entertainment'))))" | less
```

What it found

Nothing, and that sentence had to be earned three times over. All 531 passages the seven desks hand an answering agent are, today, what the publisher publishes: **0 differs, 0 could not**. The run this morning said 533 and two; the one before it said 88 differences. What changed in between is the record and the checker, and both are worth reading before this figure is believed.

The three findings this run closed, each fixed in the record rather than in the check.

- **Right text, wrong link — three passages.** The rewards desk stored § 6041, § 6041A, § 6050W and § 6071 under ONE source whose recorded URL is the House's granule for **§ 6041 only**. All four bodies were **verbatim correct**, so nothing served was ever wrong and no test in the repository could have seen it — a reader following the citation for three of the four simply landed on a page that did not contain it. **Only opening the link finds this**. Split into four sources, four URLs, each verified live; and the record now has a test comparing the URL a citation is really on with the URL its source claims.
- **A partial quotation that did not say it was one.** Publication 583's sentence has two branches and the cash desk stored the second without marking the omission. The split is right — the branches have opposite answers, which is the defect #264 found — but an answerer could not tell a branch had been removed. Marked now with [. . .], and the mark is CHECKED rather than excused: every segment must appear in the live document, in order.
- **A publisher's interface text inside a quotation.** irs.gov appends the word **PDF** to links that point at PDFs, and one sits mid-sentence on the tangible-property page. Ours dropped it. This was judged in our favour this morning and left; it is the same unmarked omission as Pub 583, and it is marked now. It was the last difference in the corpus.

What "nothing" is worth here. Three of the 531 tied only because a marked omission was checked segment by segment, and 13 tied only once whitespace was ignored. Both are declared, both are counted on each desk's own sheet, and neither is silently folded into the headline. A clean run that hides how it got clean is the thing this exhibit exists not to be.

What I got wrong

The first run reported 88 differences and 34 of them were mine. The extractor replaced every markup tag with a space, so eCFR's election</I>—(1) came back as election - (1) and 601.601(d)(2)(ii)(<I>b</I>) as (b). A checker that invents differences is worse

than no checker, because somebody goes and "fixes" the record to match it. Inline tags now close up and only block tags become a space.

Then it reported 18, and 16 of those were mine too. pypdf reads a kerned two-column IRS page as `Y ou` and hyphenates `infor-mation` across a line break, and `irs.gov` puts block markup inside a sentence. Those are rendering artefacts of the extractor, not differences in what was published — so the comparison now runs twice, and the exhibit says which pass carried each line rather than quietly folding them together.

I could not capture the sources as photographs, and the skill asks for photographs.

This machine's browser cannot reach the publishers even when pointed at the egress proxy — `ERR_CONNECTION_RESET` — while the HTTP client reaches them fine. Attempted, failed, recorded. What is here instead is the document itself: its SHA-256, its length, the moment it was fetched and the publisher's own words quoted around each match. For text that is the stronger evidence, because a reader can recompute the hash and a screenshot cannot be re-verified at all.

What this does not prove

- **It proves the words, not the reading.** That § 1.263(a)-1(f)(1)(ii)(D) says \$500 is now established. Whether \$500 is the number that governs a client is a question about Notice 2015-82 and about the firm's election, and no fetch settles it.
- **It proves containment, not completeness.** The check asks whether our passage occurs in the publisher's document. It does not ask whether we stored the *whole* of what that citation covers — a passage could be a true fragment of a paragraph whose second half changes its meaning. Publication 583 above is exactly that failure caught by accident, not by design.
- **The whitespace-ignoring pass can hide a genuinely missing space.** 13 lines tied only on that pass. Each is named in the roster as `spacing` so nobody has to take it on trust.
- **The regulations were fetched as of 2026-08-28, not today.** eCFR's versioner refuses a future date and this is the last date known good on it. A regulation amended between that date and now would not show here.
- **One reading, not two.** The skill asks for a second rendering where one exists — the XML and the rendered page, the PDF and the HTML. Only one rendering per source was read. A digit or a word wrong in *both* our copy and the one rendering we read would pass.
- **Nothing here touches whether a desk answers well.** This is about the authority it is given. A desk with a perfect corpus can still reason badly from it, and that is what the scoreboard is for.